

Battle of the Sexes

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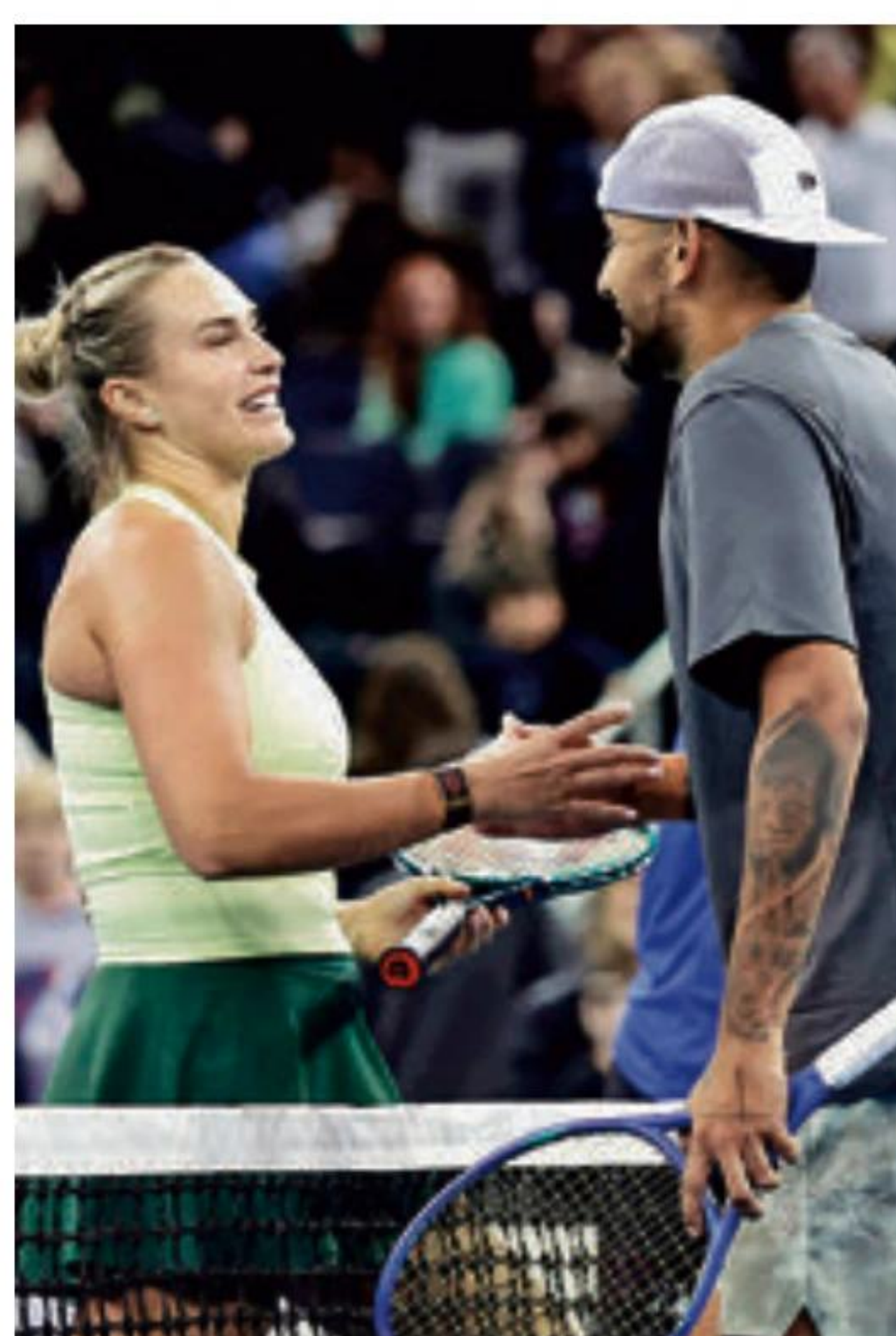
Sport has seen such battles as man vs machine (chess), and man vs animal (athletics), but for sheer pointlessness it is difficult to beat a man vs woman encounter. Especially in tennis, and especially today when the Grand Slams offer equal pay. As Chris Evert said when she was the reigning queen, "Even the 100th ranked men's player can beat me easily."

It would shock no one to learn that the money on offer for the so-called *Battle of the Sexes: Dubai Showdown* between Aryna Sabalenka and Nick Kyrgios might run into millions (they are keeping it a secret). The amount will tell us what the players charge to look ridiculous and make a mockery of the sport that has already earned them millions.

In the 1970s, fresh from beating Margaret Court, the hustler Bobby Riggs took on Billie Jean King in the 'Battle of the Sexes' (\$100,000, winner-take-all). Millions must have hoped the loud-mouth Riggs, 55, would get thrashed by King, 29. Riggs, like Jack Kramer, had nothing good to say about women's tennis, and plenty bad even if some of that had to do with attracting a television audience. Five decades later, Kyrgios is reprising Riggs.

King famously beat Riggs, and as she said, "launched the fight for parity into the worldwide limelight." That was a boost to the women's movement.

Now, the agency that represents both Sabalenka and Kyrgios is promoting the showdown between them which makes the whole thing more laughable. It will not



Money matters: The agency that represents both Aryna Sabalenka and Nick Kyrgios is promoting the showdown between them which makes the whole thing more laughable. GETTY IMAGES

do anything for women's tennis if Sabalenka wins. If she loses, the toxic masculinity of the likes of Kyrgios will fill social media posts with more hatred. Only the two players and their common agent will be laughing all the way to the bank.

The pointlessness of such encounters, however, didn't stop Jimmy Connors, 40, taking on Martina Navratilova, 35, at the *Battle of Champions* for a guarantee of \$650,000 each and \$500,000 for the winner.

Connors said later he had placed a million-dollar bet that he would lose no more than eight games. He won 7-5, 6-2. Seven decades earlier, Bill Tilden, 28, had beaten Suzanne Lenglen, 21, in a single-set match. Years later Tilden is reported to have said, "Someone won 6-0, but I don't recall who it was." It was played in fun. Television hadn't been invented yet.

Top-ranked Sabalenka is 27 while Kyrgios 30, is ranked in the 660s. He is not a regular on the circuit, having played just five matches this year. He is frequently injured and increasingly getting better known for his vile sexism and the court case where he admitted to assaulting his ex-girlfriend.

Sabalenka's court will be nine per cent smaller because someone figured women move nine per cent slower. Gimmickry is at the heart of artificial contests in sport.

You can, of course, see this as harmless entertainment on live television, and forget the prize money, the betting, the fact that one agency is in charge of everything. Maybe you can, but I can't.